

CH☆SEN
FOR BLOOD

created by

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☆

PART I
"TRIBE"

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OVER BLACK.

LESTER (O.S.)
In the beginning.
(clearing throat)
This is before there was nothin'.
I'm talkin' no heaven, no earth,
just darkness upon the face of the
deep. And you know what He said?

FLAME SPARKS - illuminating a:

STORAGE CLOSET

where LESTER LEVINE (90) watches the flame dance on the round waxy stage of a shabbos candle.

ERNESTO (O.S.)
Let there be light.

LESTER
Bingo.

Lester spots something on a shelf. Drops the matches. Starts stuffing some crinkly inventory under the seat of his walker.

ERNESTO (O.S.)
We have the same thing in our book.

LESTER
Ernie.

He grins at the uniformed attendant. Nametag: ERNESTO (18).

LESTER (CONT'D)
It's the same book.

DOOR OPENS--

Shit. Lester quickly blows the candle as a:

MANAGER marches in. Glares at the terrified Ernesto.

MANAGER
Ernesto? What's going on? You know
residents can't be back here. And
why do I smell burning?

Lester pushes his walker between Ernesto and the manager.

LESTER
Ease off. It's his first week. This
was all me.

MANAGER
(deep sigh)
I know that, Lester.

He pushes open the door...

INT. GOLDEN GROVE - DAY

...revealing a tastefully appointed senior living community.
Ernesto helps Lester into the hall. Before they get too far--

MANAGER
Wait. Pockets.

Ernesto stops.

MANAGER
Not you.

The tennis balls on Lester's walker squeak to a halt. He turns to the Manager. Eye contact. It's a standoff...

...until he hands over three butterscotch candies from his pocket. The Manager nods with begrudging respect.

MANAGER
Take Lester to get dressed. He's reading the Megillah tonight.

The Manager marches off. Lester turns to Ernesto, brows up.

LESTER
It's quite an honor.

Then flashes a smile, revealing:

a sticky piece of butterscotch on his tooth.

Lester flips open the seat on his walker, stuffed with Werther's Originals. Slips a few to Ernesto, who chuckles.

Then they proceed down the hall...

...passing walls of Jewish-themed art, wood bookcases of Hebrew texts, tables of Mahjong, chattering seniors...

...and staff unboxing Purim masks and groggers.

ANNOUNCEMENT (V.O.)
Happy Purim, Golden Grove!

SUPERIMPOSE:

BROOKLYN, NY
י"ד באדר תשע"ג
 14th of Adar, 5773

ANNOUNCEMENT (V.O.)
 Reminder that visitor's from Beth
 Shalom will be arriving at 6PM this
 evening. Anyone with medication--

CUT TO:

TENNIS BALLS

dragging on the back feet of a walker.

INT. GOLDEN GROVE - RECREATION ROOM - NIGHT

REVEAL Lester, in a suit, sliding across the decorated room
 to a table of elegantly dressed LADIES. The hot girl clique.

LESTER
 Ladies.

LADY 1
Lester. LADY 2
Lester.

LADY 3
 You're looking extra feeble.

Lester performs a near PUSHUP on his walker. But these ladies
 are unimpressed. He lets out an exaggerated sigh.

LESTER
 Do I not deserve forgiveness?
 (transferring to chair)
 On today of all days?

LADY 2
Purim is about vengeance.

LESTER
 For Haman!

Lady 2 noisily twirls a GROGGER at the name just as--

VISITING SENIORS start pouring through the door behind them.

LADY 1
Lester. Why don't you use that
 sweet mouth to see if any *Beis*
Moishe men can still drive a car?

LADY 2
That's disgusting.

LADY 1
It's not innuendo. I have
appointments!

She takes notices of Lester's unusual silence.

LADY 1
Oh don't be jealous, Lester. Dr. Oz
says negative emotions contribute
to cognitive decline.

But he's just staring, behind them...

...at a MAN in velcro shoes, rubbing a RUBY RING. When the
Man starts making his way toward the restrooms--

LESTER
I uh, I need the john.

Lester rises, grabs a Purim mask, and scoots away.

LADY 3
Hey I decorated that!

LADY 1
No you didn't.

HALLWAY

The man with the ruby ring ambles through a door.

Moments later, Lester appears. Thinks. Then enters the:

MEN'S ROOM

and heads for the sink. Flips on the faucet. But doesn't wash
his hands. Just stares through a mirror at:

two velcro shoes under the stall door.

FLUSH.

Lester straps on the Purim mask.

Then the Man emerges from the stall. Shuffles to the sink
next to Lester and washes his liver-spotted hands.

LESTER
Nice ring.

RUBY RING

Huh?

Lester looks down at the man's ruby ring.

LESTER

I said that's a nice ring.

Eyes meet in the mirror.

LESTER (CONT'D)

Wonder where you got it.

Lester pulls off the Purim mask--

RECREATION ROOM

A MEGILLAH scroll is carefully unrolled as attendants and residents get set for the Purim meal and celebration.

ATTENDANT

Where's Lester? Isn't he reading?

HALLWAY

The attendant heads toward the men's room, shouting:

ATTENDANT

Lester?

MEN'S ROOM

Lester quickly rinses his hands. Snatches his walker.

LESTER

Coming!

He leaves the sink running and races out to the:

HALLWAY

where the young, female attendant is waiting.

ATTENDANT

They're about to serve dinner.

LESTER

How 'bout some dessert?

Lester smoothly slips her a butterscotch.

ATTENDANT
Aren't you the sweetest?

She holds out a hand to assist. But he takes her arm instead.

Lester guides her like a gentleman down the hall...

...tennis ball on the back of his walker streaking:

a wobbling, crimson stripe of BLOOD on the floor.

After they've turned the corner--

A custodian emerges with a cart to collect trash. Notices the stripe. Follows it...opens the door to the:

MEN'S ROOM

and SCREAMS as he falls back into the door.

In the sink, water continues running with a SHHHH...

INT. ADAM & MERYEM'S - SHOWER - NIGHT

...SHHHH of steamy water raining down on:

ADAM (30s), sitting on a marble bench in the shower.

His phone - sealed in a ziplock bag - plays a history documentary attached to a bluetooth speaker.

When an email pops up "RE: CONFLICT MANAGEMENT SESSION #3", he waits patiently, counting...until it dissapears. Exhale. Doesn't hear from the other room:

MERYEM (O.S.)
Adam!

LIVING ROOM

MERYEM (30s, pretty pregnant) reclines on the sofa, drinking tea in a glass, watching Turkish TV on YouTube. Shouting:

MERYEM
Adam!!

Beside her: her BABA (70) watches his own videos on his own iPhone with earbuds in - grinning widely at unseen content.

MERYEM
ADAM!!!!!!

BATHROOM

Adam hears it this time. An emergency! He jumps to his feet--
SLIPS ON HIS ASS.

LIVING ROOM

Adam, holding his hip in a towel, races out.

ADAM
Are you okay?

MERYEM
Can we eat rice on Purim?

ADAM
I thought something was wrong.

ANNE (O.S.)
Pilaf is good?

Meryem's mom, ANNE (60), raises a bag of rice in the kitchen.

ADAM
Rice is fine, Annem. Teşekkürler.

Adam gives her a big, appreciative kiss on the cheek. Anne practices the English phrase back:

ANNE
Rice...*is fine.*

ADAM
(back to Meryem)
You're thinking of Passover.

Baba SHRIEKS IN JOY at whatever he's watching.

MERYEM
So what do we eat on Purim?

ADAM
I think just the triangle cookies?
It's not one of the important ones.

He reaches to open the bathroom door but--

MERYEM
I'd know this if I did that class.

ADAM
I thought we talked about this.

Adam stops in his tracks.

MERYEM

Well I'm still talking, Adam.
 (looking down at belly)
 I just want us all to be the same.

ANNE (O.S.)

Same...is good.

He accepts this calmly. Approaches. Bends beside her.

ADAM

This is America. We're Americans.
 (hand on tummy)
 And it's our choice who they are.

She makes a face. *Is it?*

BUZZ BUZZ

Adam finds his BUZZING phone.

Sees a call from GOLDEN GROVE SENIOR COMMUNITY.

CUT TO:

BEDROOM

Adam, grave, speaks with the Manager from Golden Grove.

ADAM

I don't understand. Do you need me
 to come tonight?

MANAGER (PHONE)

It's pretty hectic right now. I
 just wanted you to be aware. But
 it's better if you come tomorrow.

Adam looks out the door to his packed apartment...

ADAM

It's okay. I'm on my way.

...hangs up. He puts on pants as Meryem pokes her head in.

MERYEM

Adam? Who is it?

MANAGER (PRE-LAP)

--a class A mensch. And a bonafide
pillar of the community.

EXT. GOLDEN GROVE - NIGHT

Adam pulls up to the senior home. Next to an AMBULANCE.

MANAGER (PRE-LAP)(CONT'D)
I mean, the guy was President of my
synagogue growing up.

INT. GOLDEN GROVE - OFFICE - SAME

REVEAL two DETECTIVES interviewing a distraught Manager.

MANAGER (CONT'D)
Sure, he can be a bit of...*rascal*.
But it's never anything serious.
And the staff, they adore him.

DOOR OPENS and Adam charges in, unsure what to say.

DETECTIVE
Is this the son?

MANAGER
Grandson.
(rising to greet him)
Good to see you, Adam. It's been a
while. At least since your father
passed. I was so sorry to hear--

ADAM
What happened? Is he okay?

Manager exchanges a look with Detectives. *How to say this?*

HALLWAY

Adam and the Manager look through the glass window at:
LESTER, sitting in the library. Looking out another window.

MANAGER
I grew up going to the shop with my
brother Mitchell. Did you ever meet
Mitch? He was class of '95 at--

ADAM
Sorry. I can't do Jewish geography
right now. I'm on another planet.

MANAGER
I get it. We've had fights here
before. But nothing like this. And
between two total strangers...

ADAM
So what? It's a stroke? Dementia?

MANAGER
Well, Adam, I'm not a doctor...
(hands up, *don't sue me*)
Though when I saw him earlier, he
seemed...*normal*. But he hasn't said
a word since. Which, for him, is...

He trails off. But Adam gets the point. A beat, then:

MANAGER
Like everything, Adam, the brain
decays. And sometimes, it acts
in...*unpredictable* ways. But that
doesn't change who he is.

Adam sighs as he looks through glass into the:

LIBRARY

where Lester is staring at the window. It's dark out, and
light inside - so it's fully reflective.

MANAGER (V.O.)(CONT'D)
Whatever happened tonight, your
grandfather is still the same
wonderful man we've always known.

In the reflection, Lester lifts his lip, revealing:

A SLOTCH OF BLOOD on his front tooth.

RUTH (PRE-LAP)
Lester Mordechai Levine.

MATCH CUT TO:

A SLOTTCH OF BUTTERSCOTTCH

on the front tooth of LESTER "SWEETS" LEVINE (14).

RUTH (O.S.)(CONT'D)
What'd I tell you about staying
away from that candy shop?

INT. LEVINE APARTMENT - MORNING (1937)

RUTH (barely 30, too young to be this frail) inspects her
son's teeth in their dusty mouse-hole apartment.

RUTH (CONT'D)
Go rinse this mouth out.

SWEETS
But I gotta get to school.

RUTH
You'll wait for Samael.

SWEETS
No, Ma. He's--

She grabs his lips, holds them closed.

RUTH
Lashon Ha-rah is worse than murder.
She releases his, unleashing:

SWEETS
But it's true. He smells like--
Ruth smacks him across the back of his head.

Just then, SAMAEEL (14) emerges from a tiny second "bedroom".
Clothes tattered. Face dirty. She barks at him in Yiddish:

RUTH
Hurry up.
(then, nicely, in English)
Where's your mother?

SAMAEEL
She...job.

Ruth double checks the second bedroom. Empty.

RUTH
So you'll meet her at the factory
after school?

Samael nods. Ruth pushes him toward Sweets. Watches the boys
walk out the door. Then mutters to herself:

RUTH
Good boys.

EXT. BROOKLYN STREET - CONTINUOUS

Sweets leads Samael onto a street swelling with push carts,
newspapers, amputees, and the gray-yellow fog of morning.

SUPERIMPOSE:

BROOKLYN, NY

י"ד באדר תרצ"ז

14th of Adar, 5697

Sweets makes eye contact with a younger-looking boy working with his family, selling garments, making change - *quickly*.

This is MAURICE "SHUSH" RAPPAPORT (12).

Shush hands his job to his competent, but less swift SISTER. Then hurries to Sweets, tapping a cracked but working watch: *we're late!* But doesn't say a word. He rarely does.

SWEETS

I know. I got the import.
(nodding to Samael)
Sammy, this is Shush.

Shush tucks away his prized possession: a tattered comic book. Then reaches to shake Samael's hand. But Samael just stares at it, unsure about the gesture.

SAMAEL

Sa-ma-el.

SWEETS

Maybe to your mother.

Sweets leads the boys down the block, walking backwards.

SWEETS

But out here, you need a name that
does the talking for you. A name
you earn. That's rule #1. There's
nothing more importa...

Sweets trails off as his eyes get stuck on passing Seminary Schoolgirls. He whistles after them.

SWEETS

Excuse me, pretty birds! You're
walkin' the wrong way! I'm over
here! I can show you the park!

Ignored, he notices Samael staring at the girls.

Sweets snorts as he leads the boys into a tenement street market...and the cacophony of the crowd rises.

But they navigate with ease, ducking and sidestepping their way through the dense thrum of humanity.

Sweets nudges Samael before he's hit by a passing wood beam.

SWEETS (CONT'D)
 Watch your head, moron. Let's call
 that the next rule.

SAMAEL
School.

SWEETS
 Yeah yeah. We'll get you to school.
 They shrink in size before the rising city.
 But out here, they're nearly men.

OPENING CREDITS

QUEUE *You Want It Darker* by Leonard Cohen

A newsreel journey flies through Jewish & American history:

- Haym Salomon, Polish-born Jew of the American Revolution.
- The Statue of Liberty, Emancipation, the Dust Bowl.
- Manischewitz established. Prohibition. Bootlegging.

Flashing between newsreels: historical footage of garment workers & picket lines; pick pockets & crime scenes; mug shots, police, feds, & gangster court hearings.

Then biblical paintings: Eve & the Serpent, Cain & Abel, the Binding of Isaac, Yocheved placing Moses' basket in the Nile.

SUPERIMPOSE:

CHOSEN

The word remains on screen as--

FLAMES swallow the paintings and photographs behind it...

...leaving only billowing smoke...

...and the remaining title:

FOR BLOOD

MATCH CUT TO:

SMOKE BILLOWING

...from a cigarette outside:

ROSIE GOLD'S CANDY SHOP

Neighborhood anchor of criminal activity - ranging from petty to violent to corrupt - depending on tier:

- Young lookouts and pickpockets hang out by the front.
- Robbers and brawlers unload stock in the back.
- Older Heavies play cards and pool in the basement.

INT. CANDY SHOP - DAY

DING goes the door as the boys stroll inside and find:

ROSIE (50) reigning behind a counter. Her big, calloused hands always in motion. When she sees Sweets:

ROSIE

Nuh uh. I told you boys: no work on weekdays. I'm not taking any more heat from the mothers.

SWEETS

Listen, ma'am--

ROSIE

No ma'ams, Lester. You think you can get whatever you want with that mouth of yours. But one day you're gonna talk yourself to death. At least learn how to use it in school.

SWEETS

Its yeshiva. What am I going to learn? How to bow?

ROSIE

None of my business.
(going about her business)
And this ain't none of yours.

SWEETS

(nodding to Samael)
But he just washed up last week.
and is dyin' to earn. You know
streets paved with gold and all
that. Been calling him "Thirsty".

Sweets looks at Shush, who shakes his head. *That's not good.*

ROSIE

He looks hungry.

Sweets considers. Hm. But Shush shakes his head again.

ROSIE

He got other hungry people who are gonna come bother me?

SWEETS

People? There's no people. Its just his ma, and she's at the factory. She doesn't even speak English.

SAMAEEL

I...English...good.

SWEETS

See? Two eyes, two legs, and he can whistle. For work like this, that's all you need. And take it from me--

ROSIE

Enough! Do you ever shut up?

Sweets smiles. *When he gets what he wants!* She exhales.

ROSIE

Alright. There's a game behind Arlen's. Been going all night. Go see if any of the boys wanna switch before the Kid comes to collect.

EXT. ARLEN'S GROCERY - DAY

MEN HUDDLE around playing cards. Barking and mumbling.

Sweets, Shush, and Samael walk by...

...to a corner, where a BOY - a little older - stands watch.

SWEETS

I hear someone's sleepy.

BOY

Fuck off Lester.

(marching off)

I actually got real work to do.

Once he's at a safe distance, Sweets gestures jerking off.

SWEETS

Oh we all know about your job.

(arm over Samael)

Alright, this is easy. Go stand on that corner over there. You see any cops or anyone looking strange, you whistle. That's it. Got it?

SAMAEEL
This...is school?

Sweets looks over at the gambling men. Basically.

A LITTLE LATER

Game continues. Sweets now runs the corner. Shush and Samael nearby keeping lookout in other directions.

After a bit: a baby-faced, short man with long gorilla arms and a deep scar from chin-to-chest rounds the corner.

This is THE KID (19).

But Samael doesn't know that yet.

He tries to whistle, but can't do it.

So he steps back...and when the Kid passes by--

SAMAEEL TACKLES HIM to the ground.

SWEETS
Samael, no!

Sweets races over.

But the Kid already has Samael flipped on his back, with a KNIFE right under his chin.

SWEETS
Mr. Kid, please. He doesn't who you are. Really. He's fresh off the boat from...*Europe*, I think. This is his first day comin' with us--

KID
Stop talking.

Kid rises, keeping the knife pointed down at Samael.

SWEETS
But Rosie sent him with us to do lookout. He just didn't know who to look out for. Please. Mr. Kid--

KID
When are you gonna learn?
(turning knife to him)
I said: shut. The fuck. Up.

Kid presses his boot down on Samael's chest.

KID
And never call me Mister.

But Samael doesn't flinch. Kid looks down on him.

KID
Does it have a name?

SAMAEEL
Samael.

KID
Snail?

Kid lifts his foot off Samael--

--who jumps right to his feet, set to attack Kid again but--

Sweets grabs Samael from behind, holds him back.

Kid steps forward. Face to face with Samael. Sweets can taste the tension. But:

KID
I like him. Keep him on our side.
Whatever the fuck you call him.

SWEETS
We're working on it.

Kid snorts. Then WHISTLES to the men:

KID
Alright, game's over!

The men GROAN and started handing coins to the Kid.

KID
You heard me. Settle up, go lie to
your women. We'll see you tonight.

Kid collects more coins. Then slaps a few into Sweets' chest.

He tips an imaginary hat at Samael as the boys head off.

EXT. BROOKLYN STREET - DAY

SCREAMING and CRYING echoes off brick buildings.

Sweets, Shush, and Samael pass a gathering crowd.

Shush spots a pale, stiff body of a teenage boy just before its covered in a BLANKET. But the other two ignore it.

SWEETS

You're lucky you're alive. What
kinda animal jumps The Kid?

(aha!)

"Animal" could be a good name.

SAMAEEL

Kit?

SWEETS

Kid Twist. Cuz he'll twist your
inside...out.

He impersonates the Kid's gorilla arms. Samael understands.

SAMAEEL

Kit is...id?

SWEETS

Id?

SHUSH

Y-y-yid.

SWEETS

Ohhh. Jew. Yeah. He's one of us.
But this ain't the Old World pal,
or wherever the fuck you're from.
In this city, you're the only one
who can keep you safe.

(to Shush)

You think he understands?

SAMAEEL

Człowiek człowiekowi wilkiem.

Shush shakes his head. No.

Sweets stops by an alley to enunciate so Samael understands.
Holds up 3 fingers:

SWEETS

Rule num-ber 3. In the streets--

(gesturing to streets)

--its e-very man for him-self.

(gesturing to one another)

Jew or no Jew. Get it?

TEEN 1 (O.S.)

Did I hear a Jew?

Two fully pubescent TEENS emerge from the alley.

TEEN 1 (CONT'D)
Or no Jew?

TEEN 2
What sound's it make when it walks?
(miming shaking a bag)
Cling cling cling.

The Teens laugh as they close in on Sweets.

TEEN 1
Coming from a game?

SWEETS
Going to *school*. Ever heard of it?

Teen 1 SPITS right onto Sweets's shirt.

TEEN 2
Fuckin' godless Jews think they're
better than us.

Sweets steps back, assessing how much bigger they are.

But Samael steps forward--

--until Teen 2 swings a KNIFE to him.

TEEN 2
Easy there, big boy.

Shush nearly wets himself at the site of the knife...

...and takes off running. Teens laugh. Then turn to Samael:

TEEN 2
You can go too, if you're scared.
Just give us your Jew money.

Samael looks at Sweets, who's on the inside of the alley. No getting away for him.

But Sweets nods to run. GO!

Samael backs up, uncertain...then runs away.

TEEN 1
Why are Kikes are such cowards?

TEEN 2 raises the knife to Sweets--

--slices his pocket open.

CLANK of the coins to the ground.

A FEW MINUTES LATER

WRAPPED UP BODY of the teenage boy is loaded on a wagon.

Though his MOTHER isn't crying anymore. When she sees Sweets passing - roughed up, pockets ripped - she makes eye contact. Silent, but seemingly saying something. A warning.

PRE-LAP: MORE CRYING OF A WOMAN

INT. BROOKLYN HOUSE - DAY

ESTHER (50s) sobs in a modest, well-kept home.

Men, women, children pick at kugel and cake.

This is a shiva.

GRIEVING GUEST (O.S.)
Esther. Parents should never have
to say goodbye to their children.

She looks across the room at ABRAHAM (60s), who wears a shawl and prays with other men. She melts further into her tears.

GRIEVING GUEST (O.S.)(CONT'D)
Please. This isn't your fault.

DING DONG

EXT. BROOKLYN HOUSE - SAME

An older couple walks in the front door.

Down the street: a baby blue Cadillac faces the house.

GRIEVING GUEST (V.O.)(CONT'D)
Only one man is responsible.

INT./EXT. CADILLAC - SAME

The Kid sits in the driver's seat.

KID
You sure you wanna do this?

ACE (O.S.)
You sure you wanna question my
judgement?

The Kid quickly shuts up.

ACE (O.S.)
How many?

Kid looks out the window. Shrugs.

ACE (O.S.)
Kid. Why do I gotta keep telling
you this?

REARVIEW MIRROR

The attentive eyes of ACE GREENSPAN (30s).

ACE (CONT'D)
Count everything.

Reclining in a tailored suit and Tuscan loafers, Ace peeks in the window of the house. In a FLASH: he's able to visualize the people inside. All the faces. A superpower of sorts.

ACE
Gotta be at least 50 in there.

KID
Jesus. How do you do that?

But Ace just smirks and twists the RUBY RING on his elegant, well-manicured finger. Then gets out of the car.

INT. YESHIVA - DAY

Boys of all ages sit with dusty books in long rows of wooden tables as a TEACHER drones on in the front.

Sweets slips in and spots: Shush and Samael, but there are no seats next to them. So he sits at another table.

Grabs a book. Like he's been there the whole time.

DAVID (O.S.)
Not as slick as you think, Lester.

DAVID, a 20ish rabbi in training, peers over his book.

SWEETS
I'm here. I'm studying.

DAVID
But are you learning?

SWEETS
I'm sorry. Am I in trouble?

David sees he's been roughed up.

DAVID

We're all in trouble, Lester. Even
when we're safe. We're Jews.

SHUSH AND SAMAE

listen to the Teacher attentively as he reads:

TEACHER

--and when Haman saw that Mordecai
did not bow down, Haman was filled
with fury. But he disdained to lay
hands on Mordecai alone. So Haman
sought to destroy *all* the Jews, the
people of Mordecai, throughout the
whole kingdom. And Haman said:

(clearing throat)

*"Their laws are different from
those of every other people, so
that it is not to the King's profit
to tolerate them."*

(turning page)

So the king took his signet ring
from his hand and gave it to Haman
and said *"do with them as it seems
good to you."* And letters, sealed
with the King's signet ring, were
sent by couriers to all the King's
provinces with instruction to
destroy, to kill, and to annihilate
all Jews, young and old, women and
children, in one day...

DAVID

turns back to Sweets with a thoughtful look.

DAVID

You know, your brother knew--

SWEETS

(dropping book)

My brother don't know Babe Ruth
from Mickey Mantle.

Heads turn. David plays it off with a cough. Then picks up
the book, gesturing for Sweets to kiss it--

But Sweets ignores this. So David kisses it for him. Hands it
back. Then leans in, serious:

DAVID

You're a man now. At least in here.

This grates Sweets exactly as David intended.

SWEETS

I know how to take care of myself.

DAVID

Is *that* what that means?

(hm?)

People listen to you, Lester. The strong have a special obligation.

(eyes meeting on Samael)

We're a tribe in more than name. It is our duty to protect one another.

SWEETS

Trust me. He can protect himself.

DAVID

I'm not talking about the body.

(touching chest)

I'm talking about the *neshama*.

Judaism is not a negotiation.

SWEETS

Tell that to the Talmud.

An ANCIENT RABBI emerges from the dust--

Everyone stands in respect as he slowly drifts to his chair. Once he's passed, David whispers:

DAVID

You're clever, Lester. But that does not make you *wise*. And if you ever *read* the Talmud, you'd know that all interpretations converge on a single truth: no one is beyond His judgement. Not you. Not me.

The Rabbi sits. Everyone sits.

DAVID (CONT'D)

Not even *Ace Greenspan*.

Sweets clenches his teeth.

SWEETS

Never heard of no *Ace Greenspan*.

(exaggerated shrug)

And whoever he is, I'm sure he's never heard of *Lester Levine*.

Sweets picks up his book. Mumbles to himself:

SWEETS
But he will.

DAVID
Careful, Lester. And remember that
Haman's fatal sin wasn't violence.
It wasn't even hatred.

EXT. BROOKLYN HOUSE - DAY

Ace passes the front of the house. Heads to the back.

DAVID (V.O.) (CONT'D)
It was pride.

BACKYARD

Ace looks in the window. Makes eye contact with Esther.
Seeing him seems to make her physically ill.

After a moment, Esther discretely steps out of the back door.

ESTHER
How dare you?

ACE
Relax. I'm here to pay my respects.

ESTHER
There is nothing respectful about
this. It's a *shanda*.

Esther turns back to the window, ensuring no one inside can
see them.

ESTHER
Absolutely disgraceful. Even this,
you have to make about yourself.

ACE
Ma. This is about me.

INT. BROOKLYN HOUSE - SAME

Abraham mutters prayers with other aging men of the shiva. On
a table, a framed photo of the mourned: Ace. He doesn't see
through the window, above the photo:

His "dead" son talking to his wife outside.

EXT. BROOKLYN HOUSE - BACKYARD - SAME

Ace peeks inside. In another FLASH: he reassesses the faces of everyone in attendance - sees a RABBI this time.

ACE

Rabbi Rosen's still upright?

ESTHER

Is this a joke? Do you know the pain you're causing our community?

ACE

The community burying me alive?

ESTHER

No one survives alone.

ACE

I have Carolyn--

ESTHER

Oy gevalt, that shiksa's name--

ACE

Isn't this why you came here? So I'd be free to make my own choices?

ESTHER

No, Arnold. We came here because we didn't want to die.

ACE

You're the one killing me--
(quickly catching volume)
And this is not why I came.

He breathes. Then hands her a thick envelope. She's aghast.

ACE

It's clean. Totally kosher.

ESTHER

You bring this...zeyvel money into your father's house?

ACE

No, I brought it *outside*. I would never disrespect the pious and just *Abraham Greenspan*.

ESTHER

(pushing envelope back)
Well we don't need it.

ACE

Ma. I know about the liver.

ESTHER

Who's complaining about the liver?
It was fresh three days ago.

She peers inside the house at the platters--

ACE

Ma.

--then back at Ace. What?

ACE

Dad.

She follows his eyes back to: Abraham. Davening inside. Oh.

ACE

He needs a real doctor.

Esther stiffens up. But remains defiant.

ESTHER

He's got Marty Hochstein.

Ace sours. *Marty Hochstein?*

ESTHER

Oh suddenly you're too good for Dr.
Hochstein? You loved him!

ACE

He's a pediatrician. I liked his
toys. And who do you think told me
that dad needs a hepatologist?

ESTHER

What's a hepalologist?

Ace rubs his temples and mutters to himself:

ACE

I'm dead to him and I still gotta
be the one saving his life.

ESTHER

You're not dead, yet. You're just
gone for now. You'll come back.
(touching his face)
You'll always be one of us.

This doesn't land right. He removes her hand from his face.

ACE

The world's moving past all that.

ESTHER

Oy vey. You think your the first Jew to think such absurdities?

(snort)

Listen to me, Arnold. You can marry this woman, buy her father's factory, you can even wear the cross yourself - *chas v'shalom*. But to them, you will always be Them. They will find a way to make that known. If not today...

Today? What is she saying? But he stays quiet.

ESTHER

Just promise you'll be careful. Oh Arneleh, please.

ACE

Ma. You know I'm always careful.

But she just grabs him by the cheeks:

ESTHER

More careful.

Then plants a big KISS on his forehead.

He slips her the envelope again. This time, she accepts.

ACE

Sorry for your loss.

EXT. YESHIVA - DAY

Shush waits outside for Sweets, embarrassed.

SHUSH

I'm I'm I'm s-s-s--

SWEETS

Don't apologize. Guy had a blade.

SHUSH

--sorry.

SWEETS

I said *don't*.

(arm over Shush)

We'll make it up.

INT. CANDY SHOP - DAY

Sweets and Shush enter...to Rosie's displeasure.

ROSIE

No no no. The Kid told me one of
you's attacked him this morning and
caused a *whole* scene. Outta your
minds to be showin' back up here.

SWEETS

That was Sam.
(getting nothing)
The snail.
(still nothing)
Thirsty!

ROSIE

Doesn't matter what you call him.
You vouched for him.

SWEETS

Vouched? Me? He was followin' us.
And he don't know nothin'. Poor guy
sees a jelly bean and think its
lunch. What am I supposed to do,
let him starve? Plus, the Kid said
said he liked it!

ROSIE

Well it ain't his store. Now scram!

EXT. CANDY SHOP - CONTINUOUS

Sweets and Shush flop out of the shop, disappointed.

SWEETS

--bunch a hooey. Don't she know
there's a depression still goin'?
Everyone's earnin', 'cept us.

SHUSH

L-l--

SWEETS

I know, Shush. I'm just sayin',
people are hungry. And we can't
even get a little taste?

Sweets unwraps a piece of toffee--

SHUSH

L-look!

--drops the toffee on the ground when he sees:

ACE'S CADILLAC rounding the corner.

INT. CANDY SHOP - DAY

The Kid marches right up to Rosie's counter.

KID
I need four eyes for tonight.

ROSIE
Ya tell me now while everyone's out?

KID
I'm tellin' you what I was told.

Out the window, Ace walks around the back of the store.

ROSIE
Alright. Take Noshy.

KID
Noshy's a face. I needs ghosts.

Rosie and the Kid's eyes meet back on the window where:
Sweets and Shush pretend not to be staring inside.

EXT. CANDY SHOP - DAY

But they are. *Are they fucked?*

SWEETS
They talking about us? Is this
'cause of Samael? Fuck, Shush,
they're gonna boil us into caramel.
Let's just get out of here--

But then Rosie opens the front door.

ROSIE
Get in here. Now.

INT. CANDY SHOP - BASEMENT - DAY

The HEAVIES (20ish) play cards and chatter. We have:

- LUCKY (charming, fun-loving, murderous)
- GURRAH (hulking, serious, religious)
- BUGSY (ready to bug out, especially if you call him Buggy)

BUGSY

--so I come to collect and this pissbrain tells me he's been robbed. Shows me the machine, and it's spillin' its guts. Grease all over the floor. But the slot, the lock, the latch - looks brand new.

GURRAH

Some stones for a barkeep.

BUGSY

I know. And he looks me straight in the face and tells me this mystery man swooped in and turned the whole place inside out. But I can see the grease all over his smock!

(leaning in)

So I tell him: you either find the man who took my take or its gonna be you turned inside out!

RING RING

Lucky rises to answer the phone. While he's away from the table, he spots Bugsy taking the cash on the table.

LUCKY

Fuck you doin' Benny? That's mine.

BUGSY

Ain't yours if you ain't got it.

Lucky hangs up and turns with venom to Bugsy but--

ACE (O.S.)

Settle down, gentlemen. It's barely 3pm and you've got work to do.

GURRAH

Ayy.

LUCKY

Ayy.

Gurrah and Lucky quickly rise as Ace descends the stairs.

GURRAH

Arnold, there is he is.

Gurrah embraces Ace, slipping him an envelope.

GURRAH (CONT'D)

Wishing you a wonderful marriage. May your seeds multiply, like the stars in the heavens, and the sand on the seashore.

LUCKY

Me too, Acey. *Muzzle Tuff*. Did I say that right?

ACE

Good enough for a wop, Luck.

Ace embraces Lucky as Lucky slips him an envelope. Behind him, Ace notices Bugsy is silent - on edge.

ACE

Benny, you got a problem?

BUGSY

I didn't say anything.

GURRAH

Benny...

ACE

He didn't say anything.

Ace gives him a look. *You got something to say?*

BUGSY

I'm a mute. These guys are tryna fuck me cuz I'm fuckin' em in cards.

ACE

What am I, Stalin?

Bugsy holds his tongue. Ace looks around, frustrated.

ACE

This is America. Talk!

BUGSY

(deep breath, fine)

Acey. You know I love you. You taught me everything I know. I'm in the bag. 100%. That's why, I just, I wanna be there for you tonight.

Ace looks around. This is clearly a common sentiment.

ACE

That is what this is?

LUCKY

We're supposed to be family. We just want to celebrate you, Acey. And Carrie too, of course.

ACE

Carolyn is marrying a reputable businessman. And reputable businessmen don't have convicted felons at their wedding.

LUCKY

(a little hurt)

My sentence was commuted.

BUGSY

And I hear Jimmy Sticks is going.

ACE

James Salawitz owns a golf course.

BUGSY

But he's as much of a crook as us.

ACE

But you don't own a golf course.

DUTCH walks in, but stays in the corner. Quiet.

ACE

Listen. I'll make it up. Gimme a little time with the factory, and soon even the sky won't be the fuckin' limit. Alright?

(off nodding heads)

So forget your fucking pride and earn like you're supposed to. This is a growing business. It's time you start acting like it.

He walks off. On his way out, he's intercepted by Dutch.

DUTCH

That new fed was in Brownsville asking about you. This Tom Dewey.

ACE

I told you to stay away from him.

DUTCH

He's a cop like any other, Ace. Trust me, I can handle it.

ACE

I know what you can do, Dutch. I said don't.

Ace marches up the stairs, leaving Dutch frustrated. But he sucks it up and turns to the guys:

DUTCH
What are we playing?

STORE ROOM

Kid heads to the back and finds a soft bread roll. Pulls a huge vat of sugar off the shelf. Digs inside: withdraws a revolver. Wraps the gun in the soft, sticky roll.

INT./EXT. CADILLAC - DAY

Kid meets Ace at the car. Sweets and Shush are waiting. Sweets can't stop smiling.

KID
Best she could do on short notice.
(nodding to Shush)
But this one's a numbers wiz.

Ace lasers in on Sweets.

ACE
What about you?

Sweets is all nerves. Like he's talking to a baseball hero.

SWEETS
I, I can count, Mr. Greenspan.

ACE
(squint)
What's 84 twice, takeaway 17?

Shush holds up his hands to signal to Sweets: one-five-one. Sweets pretends like he's thinking for a moment, then:

SWEETS
151.

Ace chuckles. Of course he saw. Then he gets in the car.

ACE
You boys ever been to a wedding?

MONTAGE

Kid drives them through late depression era Brooklyn...

...over the bridge...into Manhattan, where the depression seems to be over. Buildings are taller. Women are leaner. Everything sparkles. Sweets is frozen in awe.

INT./EXT. CADILLAC - DAY

Kid pulls up in front of a 5 star hotel. But on the street. Not in the driveway. Ace steps out.

KID
Loud mouth, with me.

EXT. HOTEL - DAY

Kid gives Sweets instructions across from the hotel.

KID
Look at that door. You see that door? In a few hours, 200 *invited* guests are comin' in. And you are gonna stand right here eyein' each and everyone one of 'em. I mean *staring*. Like you're in love. Alright? Anything funny, you find me in the car. Your silent partner--

Kid turns to Shush, who's staring into space. SNAPS--

KID
Hey! Hush-hush. Pay attention. You're gonna be across the street counting to 200. You see 201? Or anyone talking to the doorman too long? You find him, he finds me.

SWEETS
You're not going in?

KID
No wolves at this wedding. Bride's orders.

Sweets watches Ace is greeted like royalty at the door.

INT. HOTEL - BALLROOM - DAY

Ace walks through the ballroom as workers set tables.

He stops at a table, where one WORKER folds napkins. Ace snatches the napkin and demonstrates how to fold it--

ACE
Like a dove.

Ace walks off. Worker folds the napkin...not like a dove. A nervous SUPERVISOR races over and grabs the napkin.

SUPERVISOR

You heard Mr. Greenspan. Like a dove, you idiot!

BRIDAL SUITE

CAROLYN (20s, WASPy finishing school graduate) tries on her wedding dress in the mirror.

KARL (O.S.)

Carrie, my god. You're stunning.

Her father KARL (60s, portly) steps beside her in the mirror. Holding a bottle of whisky by the neck.

KARL

If your mother was here...
(whiskey glug)
Let's just thank god she's gone.

CAROLYN

Be careful with that thing. The photos will live forever.

Karl looks into his bottle with despair. But before they can continue--

DOOR OPENS and Ace swoops in.

CAROLYN

You can't see me!

Carolyn playfully races into the bathroom. Ace calls out:

ACE

I see you every night in my dreams.
(hand out to Karl)
Hi, Pop. Lookin' sharp.

Karl stares at his hand. Then shakes it. A conquered King marrying his daughter to a victorious raiding barbarian.

He offers up his whiskey. But Ace is a teetotaler.

ACE

Relax. This is gonna be great. For everyone. All you have to do tonight is have a little fun. Can you handle that? For us?

Ace throws an arm over Karl, who grumbles--

PRE-LAP: POP!

INT. HOTEL - BALLROOM - NIGHT (MONTAGE)

CHAMPAGNE POPS, GLASS SMASHES!

The band gets cooking. They play jazz and even a Hora subtle enough for most of the guests not to notice.

The crowd is a shmorgasborg of New York:

- GOYS from Carolyn's side, mostly of German extraction
- some BIG MACHERS, quasi-legit Jewish businessmen
- and everyone and anyone else Ace is determined to impress - Judges. Councilmen. Union leaders. Actors. Newspapermen.

EXT. HOTEL - NIGHT

Shush, nearby, counts guests walking in, one by one. On the other corner: Sweets admires their clothes and confidence.

INT. HOTEL - BALLROOM - NIGHT

Ace toasts from the stage. In a FLASH: he assesses the faces of seemingly everyone in attendance. Like at the shiva.

ACE

Charlie! Christopher! *Baron* - what am I saying? *Everyone!* Let's show off all that crystal I paid for.

(raising glass)

To health. To friends. To family. And to America. The land of the free. A place where we get choose our own lives.

He turns to Carolyn. Time seems to slow down.

ACE

But most importantly, to the greatest choice I ever made. My American dream. My Carolyn. To Mrs. Arnold Greenspan!

Everyone cheers. The BIG MACHERS belt out:

BIG MACHERS

L'chaim!

Ace translates for the goys:

ACE

To life!

BIG MACHERS

are stationed by the bar a little later.

GOY 1 (PRE-LAP)
Wolves at the farm.

GOYS

watch them from the other side of the room.

GOY 2 (CONT'D)
My god. Are they *all* criminals?

GOY 3
This is the cream of the crop. She
only let him invite respectable ones.

GOY 1
But who knows what they're actually
up to in their secret tongues?

GOY 3
That one owns First Federal.

GOY 2
My god. Are they *all* bankers?

GOY 1
Making a deal with these people--
(yuck)
Karl is out of his mind.

They look at Karl, who's hammered.

GOY 3
Ever since Lydia.

GOY 1
May she rest in peace.

BIG MACHER 1 (PRE-LAP)
He's completely fucked.

THE BIG MACHERS

have a corresponding whispered conversation.

BIG MACHER 2
That's right. Dead man walking.

BIG MACHER 3
You're overreacting. He'll get
through this.

BIG MACHER 1
Get through this?
(in disbelief)
It's Joe fuckin' DiMaggio. Hubbell
may have won 22 games, but it
wasn't against no god damn Yankees!

Ace swoops in for some big hugs and kisses. AYYY.

BIG MACHER 3
Acey these goys are staring at us.

ACE
No one's staring.

The Macher turns to see: the goys staring. They're staring!
But Ace is careful not to look that way.

ACE
Jimmy. It's her mother's cousins,
Forget 'em. Look by the stage.

The Machers subtly peak at a group of men. Ace doesn't look.

ACE
Dignitaries from the West. That's
Judge Bertram. And some of the
greasiest palms the Illinois
Assembly has to offer. Maybe we can
bring 'em by the course.

BIG MACHER 3
The Judge is in the yellow?

Ace sips his sparkling water - still not looking.

ACE
Navy. Munchin' on the melon.

BIG MACHER 2
How the hell do you do that?

BIG MACHER 3
Ace Greenspan can see ants from the
top of Empire State Building.

BIG MACHER 2
I mean how's a Jew like you get a
judge like that in a room like this?

ACE

Is there something wrong with a state official associating with a local factory owner?

BIG MACHER 2

It ain't even the right state.

BIG MACHER 1

You're missing the point, Solly.

ACE

Point is it doesn't matter.

BIG MACHER 2

Maybe not to you.

Ace snipes a canapé from a passing server.

ACE

You sound like my parents. You know they had a shiva for me today?

Nooooo.

ACE

I mean it. Herring. Torn clothing. The whole nine yards.

BIG MACHER 1

Mothers can be very sensitive.

ACE

Oh it wasn't her. This ruling came straight from the golden throne of Abe the Just. 55 people showed up to nosh. They even had a rabbi.

BIG MACHER 2

Your brother?

Ace doesn't respond. But the machers just blast on.

BIG MACHER 1

Oy vey is mir, your family's so dramatic. If I married a shiksa, my ma woulda just sat me down calmly...
(serious)
...and shot me herself!

BAHAHAHA--

EXT. HOTEL - NIGHT

Sweets gets a TAP on the shoulder. He jumps! It's just Shush.

SWEETS
Go back to your station.

Shush flashes numbers on his fingers: 2-0-2. What? Shush points at the hotel. Flashes: 2-0-2!

SHUSH
I c-counted.

SWEETS
Shit. Where's the Kid?

But when they turn to the car: he's not there.

FRONT DOOR

Sweets races to the door. But the DOORMAN shakes his head.

DOORMAN
Private event, kid.

SWEETS
It's an emergency. I need to talk to Mr. Greenspan. Or somebody.

DOORMAN
You wanna talk to Mr. Greenspan?
(chuckle)
We have strict orders not to let anyone else inside. Now shoo.

The Doorman pushes him away.

Sweets stumbles back toward an alley. Notices something...

INT. HOTEL - BRIDAL SUITE - NIGHT

Carolyn tumbles in with a BRIDESMAID, grinning ear to ear.

CAROLYN
I need fresh air.

She grabs cigarettes, heads for the back door.

BRIDESMAID
But Acey said stay inside--

CAROLYN
I'm not his property. I'm his wife.
Go make sure he's still dancing.

EXT. HOTEL - BACK ALLEY - NIGHT

Sweets sneaks through the alley.

He can hear MEN TALKING ahead. But can't see anything...

...until he spots red dribbles on the ground...which he follows...turning a corner to find:

TWO MASKED MEN painting a wall.

One of them bends, revealing:

a RED OCTOPUS wearing a yarmulke.

Underneath, in red paint: "Blood Sucker".

CAROLYN

steps out to smoke and sees:

a RED PIG wearing a wedding dress.

Underneath: "Kike Fucker".

Her SCREAM catches their attention.

MAN #1
Tell your Jew husband: *go to hell*

MAN #2
And stay the fuck out our business.

Man #1 SPLATTERS her dress with the rest of the red paint.

CAROLYN
THIS IS MY WEDDING DRESS!

She lunges at him and snatches away the bucket. THROWS IT over the head of Man #2 from behind.

CAROLYN
You're gonna pay for this!

She tries dragging him to the ground, but he's too strong.

So she KICKS HIS NUTS and he doubles over in pain. Man #1 charges toward her but--

SWEETS appears from behind and--

KICKS Man #1 in the knee. The man buckles to the ground.

But Man #2 rips off the bucket, PUNCHES Sweets in the gut.
Man #1 rises and they converge on Sweets.

Carolyn SCREAMS as they throw him to the ground.

INT. HOTEL - NIGHT

CHAMPAGNE POPS and the BAND PLAYS--

No one notices the noise outside. Ace is dancing without a care. Until an employee races up to him.

EXT. HOTEL - BACK ALLEY - NIGHT

Carolyn SCREAMS as the men beat Sweets.

But a HAND slips over her mouth from behind--

SHUSH (O.S.)

Shh.

Shush pulls her back from the fray as--

POP POP

The KID shoots at the men. Hitting one in the arm--

SPLATTERING BLOOD onto Sweets's face.

The Men drop him, run down the alley.

Kid SHOOTS after them, but misses just as--

Ace runs out of the hotel. The men are gone. It's just:

- The red octopus: "Blood Sucker"
- The red pig: "Kike Fucker".
- His wife, covered in red, being held by Shush.
- Sweets, beaten and bloody on the ground.
- The Kid standing with the smoking gun.

KID

I'm going after them--

ACE

Take the boys home.

KID
But Ace--

ACE
Now.

INT. HOTEL - BRIDAL SUITE - NIGHT

Ace and Carolyn tumble in. Her wedding dress stained red. Carolyn is distraught, spiraling.

CAROLYN
You promised me. You said this
wouldn't be a gangster's wedding.

ACE
And I didn't bring any guys. That
was the problem.
(off Carolyn's look)
They were outside! And *thank god*.

He takes her face gently--

ACE
Are you okay?

She SLAPS his away. Then keeps slapping him--

CAROLYN
Am I okay!? Look at me!

--SLAP SLAP until he bear hugs her. But she keeps writhing.

ACE
Didn't I buy you three other
dresses?

CAROLYN
You think this is about a dress?
(ripping herself away)
Don't play dumb with me, Arnold.
Who are those men? What do they
want from you? Do you even know?

Ace, for once, is at a loss for words.

She flops backward on the sofa. Silence...until:

CAROLYN
Just tell me. How long until I'm a
widow? Or visiting you upstate?

ACE

Carrie--

CAROLYN

No. Don't lie to me. And don't make promises you can't keep. I demand honesty, Arnold. Tell me the truth.

ACE

The truth is, you're right.

Carolyn turns away, but he's at least speaking the right language. He takes the opening to sit next to her.

ACE

I can't change where I came from or how I got here. And I can't pretend I don't have ambitions. You wouldn't be here if I didn't.

(beat)

All I can do is build the future - our future. And to cherish you, no matter what it costs.

CAROLYN

I'll believe it when I see it.

ACE

Didn't you see the Ketubah we signed tonight?

CAROLYN

That big Jew contract my father was complaining about? I don't even know what it says.

ACE

It says our fate is sealed together. Forever. But it ain't legal, so if this is too much, tell me right now. If that is what you're saying.

Sigh. She's not saying *that*. He rises and holds out his hand.

ACE

Then let's find you another dress.
(left hanging)
Please. Carrie. I'm begging you to forgive me.

CAROLYN

No you're not.

Carolyn's eyes drift suggestively to the ground. He slowly lowers himself to his knees before her.

ACE

Carolyn Greenspan. Can we forget all this happened and enjoy our magical night? Can you please forgive me, at least this once?

He looks up into her eyes. She softens.

CAROLYN

I just married you, Arnie. Of course I'll forgive you.

Then pulls him back up. Tender kiss. She whispers in his ear.

CAROLYN

But I will never forget.

BALLROOM

Ace returns with Carolyn, in a new dress. The Machers raise them right up in the chairs. And the party continues. He smiles at his wife. She returns it.

INT./EXT. CADILLAC - NIGHT

Kid drives the boys home, who are catching their breath.

After a bit, he pulls up in front of an apartment. Then turns to hand Sweets and Shush some cash.

KID

Come by the candy shop tomorrow.

Sweets's eyes light up. He nods. Jabs Shush, who also nods. Then Shush opens the door--

KID

Loud mouth. Stay a minute.

Sweets nods for Shush to head off. Sits back.

KID

You went in the alley by yourself.

SWEETS

I handled it, didn't I?

KID
No. You didn't. But now you know.
The strength of the wolf is in the
pack. Understand?

Sweets nods. Kid hands him something wrapped up in a napkin.

KID
Good. We'll see you tomorrow.

INT. SHUSH'S APARTMENT - LIVING ROOM - SAME

Shush creeps into his family's candlelit tenement.

Two women sleep on a mattress. Several others on the floor.

On a rocking chair, Shush's haggard, bearded FATHER sleeps next to a mug and a lit candle.

SMALL BEDROOM

Shush gingerly pulls up a floorboard, stashing money next to comic books and leather-bound textbooks. Returns to the:

LIVING ROOM

where he sneaks up to his father, close enough to feel his breath. Then puts out the candle. Smoke wisps in the dark.

INT. LEVINE APARTMENT - SAME

Meanwhile, Sweets sneaks into his own family's apartment. Slips past his snoring mother, who clearly fell asleep waiting for him. He covers her in a blanket.

Then unwraps the napkin: a KNIFE. Rewraps. Heads for the:

WASH ROOM

where he rinses the blood off his hands. Sees, in the mirror:

Blood on his front tooth.

MATCH CUT TO:

LESTER'S FAKE TEETH

as he opens wide for the POLICE OFFICER.

INT. NYPD - INSPECTION ROOM - NIGHT (2013)

REVEAL an officer performing a very gentle, but legally mandated cavity search of Lester.

CLIENT (PRE-LAP)
Don't let the sheepskin fool you.
The man is a carnivore.

HALLWAY

Adam talks to his corporate CLIENT on the phone.

ADAM
How else could we phrase that?

CLIENT (PHONE)
Who cares about my vocabulary? You said specifics are for the lawyers.

ADAM
That's right. But the Board hired me so we don't *need* lawyers. And emotive language will only escalate this into a personal turf war.

CLIENT (PHONE)
He's the one who made it personal.

ADAM
Then you're the one who can use this opportunity to showcase your professionalism and responsibility.
(letting this land)
There's power in restraint, Rhonda. Don't let short-term feelings get in the way of long-term goals.

BUZZZZZZ. Meryem's calling.

ADAM
I have to go. Let's review one more time before the meeting. Okay?
(off a grumble)
Good. I'll talk to you tomorrow.
(switching to Meryem)
Sorry. That was DMG. They have the pre-arbitration on Thursday.

MERYEM (PHONE)
What's going on? Should we come? My parents are embarrassed we're not there.

ADAM
Extended families don't usually
show up for every emergency here.

MERYEM (PHONE)
Well maybe if they did, there'd be
less emergencies.

INT. ADAM & MERYEM'S - SAME

Meryem's Anne serves cake and club soda as she talks to Adam.

MERYEM (CONT'D)
So. What happens now?

ADAM (PHONE)
I'm waiting to hear from Michael.

MERYEM
Which Michael?

ADAM (PHONE)
Lawyer Michael.

MERYEM
(sitting up)
Which Lawyer Michael, Adam?

MICHAEL (PHONE)
Sugar plum?

Meryem GROANS--

INT. NYPD - SAME

Adam hears the GROAN as MICHAEL (40s) approaches.

MERYEM (PHONE)
Oh, God, that little--

Adam hangs up and shakes Michael's hand. Michael hugs him.

ADAM
Meryem says hi.

MICHAEL
She must be bustin' your beans for
leaving her alone all preggos.

ADAM
She's fine. Her parents are staying
with us for a few months.

MICHAEL

Months? Jesus. I can't stand Nina's family for five fuckin' minutes.

ADAM

I like them. They get me.

MICHAEL

Oh, they speak English now?

ADAM

It's more of a...vibe.

MICHAEL

So they leave you alone.

ADAM

(moving on)

Thank you for doing this, Michael.

MICHAEL

Please. Your father woulda done the same for me, *God rest him*. And your Zayde, *I shit you not*, one of the greatest fucking men to ever step foot on these godforsaken sidewalks. It is of paramount importance to me and my firm that his liberties are protected.

(hands up)

At no cost.

Adam sits slowly. The seriousness is really setting in.

MICHAEL

Relax. Whatever happened, it's clear your grandfather is incompetent.

(hands up)

Legally, of course.

ADAM

And medically? They said there's no sign of a stroke.

MICHAEL

You'll take him to Ross Flicker tomorrow and figure it *all* out.

ADAM

Becca Flicker's little brother?

MICHAEL

He's a neurologist.

ADAM
Isn't he like 20?

MICHAEL
He's old enough to look inside your
Zayde's brain and explain why he
can't be held liable for the
condition of the man who...*fell* in
that bathroom.

ADAM
(looking up, hopeful)
Is that what they think happened?

MICHAEL
No.

Oh. Michael joins him on the bench.

MICHAEL
But the operative word is "think".
And old people, they fall. Either
way, the guy's officially comatose,
so we got some time to figure out
what really happened.
(patting back)
At no cost.
(standing back up)
Still, I should warn you: this
thing is gonna move slow. I'm
talking *glacial*. Cops gotta
interview the staff, *then* the
residents. And these crusties, they
love to yap. But they never say
anything, if you know what I mean.

Adam doesn't know what he means.

MICHAEL
They think everyone else is out to
get them. It's their kinda *Omerta*.
You know: *honor among the ancient*.

ADAM
Like the mob?

MICHAEL
Yeah yeah, *the Jewish nursing home
mafia*.

Michael snorts. Waits for Adam to laugh but--

A DOOR BUZZES.

Adam rises. Looks through a wired, safety glass window at:
a cop wheelchairing silent Lester to the discharge desk.

ADAM

Do you think he'll remember me?

MICHAEL

Remember you?

ADAM

I mean, if there's something wrong
with his brain...I haven't seen him
since the wedding.

MICHAEL

No shit. My mother mentioned a
rift. But she's usually lying.

ADAM

I wouldn't call it a *rift*. I mean,
he was *there*. Went up in the chair
and everything. And he's never said
one word about Meryem besides
"congratulations". But I could see
it, you know? The way he looked at
us. Like I wasn't his anymore.

Michael sees how difficult this is. Tries to be thoughtful:

MICHAEL

Adam. Listen. She's an *Islamic*.

This doesn't work. But Michael continues:

MICHAEL (CONT'D)

And he grew up in different era.
You need to be patient with him.
Have you tried talking? I mean,
aren't you supposed to be like, a
conflict resolution expert?

ADAM

Conflict Management Counselor. Not
everything can be resolved.

MICHAEL

Well, at least one of us is good at
his job. Because thanks to Mikey,
your grandfather will not be
spending his Purim in the precinct.

Good. But Adam waits for the but...

MICHAEL

No buts. Just a *reasonable condition* that he remains within city limits. At a legal residence.

ADAM

We sold my dad's place last year.

MICHAEL

But your grandfather has property.

ADAM

You're joking. That place is a tax credit. It should be condemned. No one's even been there since--

MICHAEL

It's the only place he's allowed to stay tonight outside this building. And you should count it as a win.
(patting shoulder)
At no cost.

INT./EXT. CAR - NIGHT

Adam talks to Meryem on speakerphone as he pulls to a curb.

ADAM

I just feel bad leaving you.

MERYEM (SPEAKERPHONE)

It's fine. I have my parents.

Adam exhales in relief. He knew she'd say this.

MERYEM (SPEAKERPHONE)

Speaking of which. We were just talking about the conversion class.

He peeks at Lester in the passenger seat. Picks up the phone.

MERYEM (PHONE)

And guess what? They're open to it. My mom says being Jewish is chic.

ANNE (PHONE)

Evet. Musevi olmak çok şık!

Then he hears BABA in the background. Meryem translates:

MERYEM (PHONE)

My father wants to know if it will help them get a green card.

MERYEM (PHONE) (CONT'D)
 (listening, translating)
 He says Jews are very influential
 with governments.

ADAM
 We just got here. I have to go
 change the sheets upstairs.

MERYEM (PHONE)
 Wait. Is he talking yet?

ADAM
 He has no idea what's going on.

Adam looks at Lester, who just stares out the window...

MERYEM (PHONE)
 Well, thank god he has you.

...at an apartment in a rundown building. On the street
 level, behind chains and graffiti:

the CANDY SHOP.

MATCH CUT TO:

EXT. CANDY SHOP - DAY (1937)

Sweets and Shush staring through the same window.

SWEETS
 This is it. Our real bar mitzvahs.

SHUSH
 Kids in a c-c-candy shop.

Sweets laughs and slaps him on the back.

SWEETS
 Not kids anymore. This is our
 portal to a new universe, like in
 those comics. You saw that hotel
 last night. Those people were
 livin' in the fucking future. And
 that's where we're headed, Shush.

KNOCK from inside scares them. It's Rosie, annoyed.

They head for the door. On the way, Sweets notices:

toffee he dropped the day before...

...being devoured by hungry ants.

INT. CANDY SHOP - DAY

The boys follow Rosie through the shop to the back.

ROSIE
Don't be lurkin' out here or I'll
have you shot. Now come on.

KITCHEN

Rosie points to a boiling pot with a wooden spoon.

ROSIE
Stir.
(handing over spoon)
Mumsy. With me.

She takes Shush up front. Sweets looks around. *What the fuck?*

UP FRONT

Sweets finds Rosie and Shush at the register.

SWEETS
I'm sorry, ma'am. But we were told
we were workin' for Mr. Greenspan.

ROSIE
What'd I tell you about Ma'am'm me?
And I don't know no Mr. Greenspan.
Neither should you. If you're here,
you're workin' for Rosie Gold.

Before Sweets can respond, Rosie holds out her hand--

Shush passes her a MASSIVE WAD of cash.

ROSIE
To the cent?

Sweets nearly chokes on the sight of the cash.

SWEETS
I am so sorry, ma'--
(catching himself)
Rosie. You obviously know what
you're doing here.

Rosie SNIFFS--

ROSIE
But you don't.

Sweets realizes the candy is burning. Shit. He races back to the kitchen. Then Rosie turns back to Shush.

ROSIE

Got a delivery coming worth \$800.
Deal is to pay installments once a
week for the rest of the year, with
a \$10 kicker each month. How much
do I pay next week?

Shush thinks. Writes down a number. Rosie smirks. Good boy.

INT./EXT. CADILLAC - DAY

Pulled over, Kid takes out the revolver.

ACE (O.S.)

No guns.

REARVIEW MIRROR

Eye contact with Ace.

KID

But Ace--

ACE

Put it away. We walk in there like
we own the place. Because I do.
(stepping out of car)
No fear. No grievance.

Without looking, he sees Kid unwrap a lollipop.

ACE

And no more suckers. You're not a
kid anymore.

Kid tosses the lollipop on the street.

INT. FACTORY - DAY

WORKERS gawk at Ace and the Kid as they stroll through. Some
of the men grumble as they go upstairs.

Like before, Ace clocks every face on the floor. Including:
Samael watching from the corner.

FLOOR BOSS (O.S.)

Get the fuck back to work.

A FLOOR BOSS SMACKS him on the head.

OFFICE

Ace meets with MUNSON, another major shareholder.

MUNSON

--terrible, just terrible. And at
your own wedding. How's the bride?

ACE

She's fine. Sends her regards.

MUNSON

I warned you about these
communists. They fight dirty.

ACE

Communists.

MUNSON

Of course, who else would commit
such a classless act?

Eye contact. Munson waits to see if Ace buys it.

ACE

Right. Disgusting rodents.

MUNSON

That's right. We spent years trying
to root them out. But a pest is a
pest. I should have warned you.

ACE

You did. Several times.

MUNSON

Well seeing it firsthand, I see how
it could it change things. And if
you wanted pull out of the deal--

ACE

The deal is done. My father-in-law
received his payment and signed the
papers, which were duly filed with
the state Wednesday. As of this
morning, I am officially majority
shareholder of this facility.

MUNSON

Nonetheless, I'm sure there's a
clause for extraordinary--

ACE

Mr. Munson, the workers don't like who they're working for. What's extraordinary about that?

WAITING AREA

Kid waits outside the office.

ACE (O.S.) (CONT'D)

I won't be intimidated by a bunch of cowardly men in masks.

A MAN with a wounded arm pops his head in. Kid notices the arm. And some red paint on his fingernails. The man sees Kid and walks right back out.

OFFICE

Ace stays patient. But Munson is anxious.

MUNSON (CONT'D)

I respect that. But respectfully, you're not the *only* shareholder. This makes things difficult for everyone. Insurance alone--

ACE

Don't worry about the insurance. I already took care of the first year up front. As a show of good faith.

MUNSON

You did?

Ace nods. Munson thinks. Hm. Okay. When he looks up:

Ace is already standing above him--

ACE

I'll make everything is nice and smooth. You'll see.

(holding out hand)

And then we'll root out these reds together. Okay?

Reluctant, Munson rises and shakes his hand.

INT./EXT. CADILLAC - DAY

Ace gets in the backseat. Kid in the front. Kid drives.

ACE

Call your blue friend. Formally report the vandalism. Tell them we suspect subversive workers from the factory. But don't say the word "Communist". I don't want that new federal fuck getting near this.

KID

You mean the Dewey guy? Dutch said--

ACE

I told Dutch to stay away. Can I least count you on you to do what the fuck I say?

Kid drives...until he hits a red light.

KID

Acey, listen. I saw the guy I popped in there. He's gotta be with Munson. This wasn't no workers.

ACE

And?

KID

And its fucking bullshit.

ACE

Let 'em have their story, Kid. We decide how it ends.

Ace sees the green light without looking.

ACE

Now drive the fucking car.

EXT. CANDY SHOP - DAY

They park the car. Kid goes in the front. Ace in the back.

INT. CANDY SHOP - BASEMENT OFFICE - DAY

The Heavies go quiet and stand when Ace descends the stairs.

BUGSY

Hate to say it, boss, but we shoulda been there.

ACE

Then why are you saying it?

GURRAH

These vermin fuck with you, they
fuck with all of us. I'm gonna--

ACE

You're gonna sit and do nothing.

Everyone looks at him like he's crazy. No one sits.

LUCKY

They insulted your woman. I'd be
happy to hang them from the bridge.

ACE

What did I just say?

The heavies look at one another. Then slowly sit.

ACE

Listen. I know each of you could
bring me a dozen scalps by morning.
But that's what they want. They
want to make it Them and Us.

They look at him like he's speaking a foreign language.

ACE

But the stone age is over,
gentlemen. As of today, we are
businessmen first. *That* is how we
conquer. Not by swaggering around
killing rivals in the street. But
by making them work for us. Blood
took us this far, but right now,
only restraint gives us strength.

GURRAH

They'll never accept you in their
world, Arnold.

ACE

I don't want their world. I want
mine.

INT. CANDY SHOP - DAY

Kid walks in. Sees Shush on the count next to Rosie.

KID

Big mouth here?

ROSIE

In the back.

Kid peers into the kitchen: sees Sweets stirring.

KID

Good. I need 'em both for tonight.

This makes Rosie uncomfortable. He pats her shoulder.

KID

I'll handle the grown up part.

(whistle)

Shush and Sweets, with me.

Sweets pops out. Him and Shush follow the Kid to the back.

KID

You know where his factory is?

SWEETS

Who?

Kid nods, good. Then opens a door to a:

KITCHEN

where he hands Shush a piece of paper.

KID

Can you remember this?

Shush reads. Nods. Kid takes it back and rips it up.

KID

You hit the door on the east alley.
Get to the 2nd floor office. Top
shelf on the desk. You find those
numbers. You memorize them. Put
everything back exactly how you
found it. And tomorrow, you report
back to me. Not tonight. Tomorrow.

SWEETS

What about me?

KID

You're lookout.

SWEETS

Again? Are you fucking kidding me?

KID

Are you fucking kidding me?

Sweets quickly retreats, but he can't stop talking.

SWEETS

I just thought I'd have a real job.

KID

You do. Get the door open.

SWEETS

How?

KID

That's the job. Listen. Your buddy
breaks numbers, I break bones. You,
you're our fixer. Door's closed?
Fix it open.

Sweets nods. He gets it. Then Kid heads out, and Sweets looks
at Shush. *How the hell is he gonna do this?*

INT. LEVINE APARTMENT - MORNING

Sweets and Samael get ready for school.

SWEETS

Thanks for this. All you need to do
is stay in the factory after your
shift and open the door.

SAMAEL

Factory close. Me open.

Sweets nods.

SWEETS

Good. We still need a nickname.

SAMAEL

Nick name.

SWEETS

Yeah. We'll figure something out.

Sweets pulls out the KNIFE Kid gave him.

INT. FACTORY - NIGHT

Samael finishes his shift. But lingers as other workers go
home for the night. Then hides under the stairs.

EXT. FACTORY - NIGHT

Sweets and Shush watch the workers leave. Shush counting.

After a bit, Shush nods to Sweets. Go time.

INT. FACTORY - SAME

Samael removes a 2x4 locking a door. Door pops open.

Shush sneaks inside. Heads right upstairs to the:

OFFICE

and finds the desk. Opens the top drawer. Withdraws a big BOOK. Flops it open. DUST releases like a religious text.

EXT. FACTORY - ALLEY - SAME

As Sweets keeps watch, he hears a few VOICES...

INT. FACTORY - OFFICE - SAME

Shush finds the right page. Scans the numbers...repeating the numbers over and over. Like he's davening.

EXT. FACTORY - ALLEY - SAME

Sweets hears footsteps approaching. Then:

TOUGH GUY 1 (O.S.)
Hey! You!

ON THE STREET

The Kid watches two TOUGH GUYS head into the alley.

He goes the other way. Picks up a stashed can of gasoline.

BACK IN THE ALLEY

The Tough Guys corner Sweets.

TOUGH GUY 1
What the fuck are you doing here?

SWEETS
Settle down, pal. I work here.

TOUGH GUY 2
Then why you do look like a thief?

Tough Guy 2 PUNCHES him in the gut. As he's hunched--
Sweets pulls out the KNIFE, but--
Tough Guy 1 slaps it away. Knife flies down the alley.
Both guys LAUGH. Then Tough Guy 1 hits Sweets in the face.

INT. FACTORY - SAME

Shush has what he came for. He races out of the office...
...down the stairs...through the back door.

EXT. FACTORY - CONTINUOUS

Shush emerges from the back door, sees, down the alley:
Sweets being beaten by the tough guys.

SHUSH
L-lester!

TOUGH GUY 2
Another one!

They drop the groaning Sweets to the ground...
...converge on Shush. From the ground, Sweets can barely
talk. But he still squeaks out:

SWEETS
Shush! Run!

Then he slowly rises to his feet...
...but limps off the other way.
Shush watches his best friend leave him. Scared stiff as the
men close in on him. He's on his own.

SWEETS

is limping down the alley. Huffing and puffing. Hearing:

SHUSH

taking blow after blow.
Tough Guy 1 raises his fist for a final pop then--

SCREAMS!

TOUGH GUY 1
What the fuck!?

He cranes his neck back to see:

He's been stabbed in the back.

SWEETS

releases the Kid's knife in Tough Guy 1's back. Grabs Shush by the collar to run away. But--

Tough Guy 2 quickly trips him--

--Sweets flops forward onto the ground. Tough Guy 2 holds him down as Tough Guy 1 pulls the knife from his own back...

...raises it above Sweets's chest...

SHUSH
L-lester!

...about to stab him...until--

DOOR SWINGS OPEN--

--KNOCKS Tough Guy 1 onto Sweets, trapping him on the ground.

Samael emerges and--

--WHACKS Tough Guy 2 in the head with the 2x4.

The knife falls to the ground.

Samael steps over to Tough Guy 1, still laying on Sweets. Before he can even plead--

SAMAEL beats the man viciously with the 2x4.

Over and over and over. Blood splattering all over his face and onto Sweets below him. Finally, Sweets gets out from under the body.

Meanwhile, Tough Guy 2 rises and charges at Samael--

But Sweets grabs the knife and STABS Tough Guy 2 in the belly. Repeatedly, until he drops to the ground.

The boys look at one another...just as:

FLAMES ERUPT INSIDE

Shush and Samael help Sweets run off from the fire.

PRE-LAP: RING RING

INT. ACE'S APARTMENT - NIGHT

Ace picks up the phone in his elegant home.

KID (PHONE)
They got it.

ACE
And the rest?

KID (PHONE)
You tell me.

Ace looks out the window at the view of Manhattan.

All the way downtown, he can see:

FLAMES rising from the factory.

CAROLYN (O.S.)
Arnie? What are you doing?

In the reflection of the window, as the flames ripple:

ACE
Fundraising.

Ace's smile.

EXT. STREET - NIGHT

Once they're a safe distance away, the boys turn back to watch the factory burn. Shush is terrified. Samael is stoic. Sweets is laughing, ecstatic, fire rippling in his eyes.

SWEETS
You did it. You fucking did it.

Sweets grabs Samael's shoulders.

SWEETS
We woulda been dead without you.

He pulls Shush into a tight circle with Samael.

SWEETS
From now on, we always protect each other. Okay? All of us.

Sweets ensures Samael understands. Shush nods too.

SWEETS
 The Kid was right. He told me.
 (still breathing heavy)
 It's the pack. That's the real
 strength of the wolf--
 (eyes wide)
 That's it. That's the name!

He takes a step back.

SWEETS
 Wolf!

Shush finally approves.

SHUSH
 Wolf.

Even Samael understands immediately.

SAMAEL
Wolf.

SWEETS
 Got a nice ring to it, huh?

RUBY RING (PRE-LAP)
 Huh?

CUT TO:

GOLDEN GROVE - MEN'S ROOM INCIDENT (FLASHBACK)

Lester looks down at the man's ruby ring.

LESTER
 I said that's a nice ring.

Eyes meet in the mirror.

LESTER (CONT'D)
 Wonder where you got it.

Lester pulls off the Purim mask.

LESTER (CONT'D)
Wolf.

CUT TO BLACK.

Darkness...

...until a FLAME illuminates:

INT. APARTMENT - NIGHT (PRESENT DAY)

Adam sets down the matchbook on the dusty coffee table.

ADAM (O.S.)
 Sorry. The bulbs must be 30 years
 old. Were you having a bad dream?

Lester huffs and puffs on a chair beside him.

ADAM
 Zayde, are you okay?
 (rising)
 Let's get you to bed.

Lester shakes his head, barely, almost without moving.

ADAM
 Wait. Do you understand me?

But Lester quickly regains his blank stare.

ADAM
 Zayde?

Adam sits back down. Not sure how to proceed. He sees the Megillah on the table. Picks it up. Enunciates:

ADAM
 Um. Okay. They sent me home with
 this Megillah. Um. They said you
 were supposed to read it tonight.
 Maybe I can read it for you now?
 Would that help settle you down?

No response. Adam opens a random page of the Megillah:

ADAM
*When Haman saw Mordechai would not
 kneel, he became filled with wrath.
 And said to King Ahasuerus, "There
 is a people scattered among us, and
 their laws differ from every people.
 It is of no use to let them be."
 (flipping pages)
 On that night the king could not
 sleep...*

Adam considers the text as he flips more pages. Stops:

ADAM

...and the king ordered they hang Haman's ten sons...and the rest of the Jews who were in the king's provinces assembled and protected themselves and had rest from their enemies and...slew their foes, seventy-five thousand. And the king took off his signet ring, and gave it to Mordecai.

(stunned)

Holy shit. 75 thousand? Does God know about this?

Adam looks over...

...but Lester's just staring at the candle.

ADAM

Zayde. Do you understand anything I'm saying?

Adam sighs. He looks down. Basically talking to himself.

ADAM

I still need to say something.

(looking at candle)

I know there's been...*distance*. But we're still family. That's why I'm here. Because I know you're a good man. And I will protect you as best I can. Okay? Meryem too. Whatever happened, we know you would never hurt anyone on purpose. We know who you really are--

Adam's mouth is suddenly covered by LESTER'S HAND.

LESTER

Shh.

The swift motion BLOWS THE CANDLE OUT.

CUT TO BLACK.

But smoke billows in the dark...

...the ghost of the flame.

ROLL CREDITS.